

IDEAS

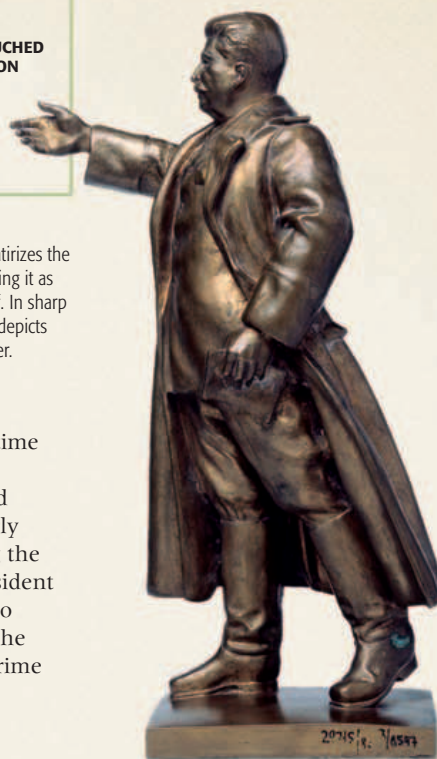
STATE CENSORSHIP

Stalin's censors distorted the past to preserve the myth of his infallibility. Individuals who had fallen out of favor were eliminated from the historical record. Retouching photographs was a striking aspect of this enforced amnesia. In charge of the secret police in 1936–38, Nikolai Yezhov, known as the “Poisoned Dwarf,” was responsible for the worst of the Stalinist purges. When he was also executed on Stalin's orders in 1940, all traces of his association with the Great Leader were eradicated. Thus Yezhov's image was removed from this photo taken at the Moscow–Volga canal.



“The death of one man is a tragedy. The death of millions is a statistic.”

JOSEPH STALIN, ATTRIBUTED



which Stalin's policies contributed. His aims were achieved, but at an astounding human cost.

Behind closed doors

The situation in the country was mirrored at Stalin's “court” in the Kremlin, Moscow, where his entourage lived in constant fear of arrest, torture, or execution. The assassination of Sergei Kirov, a member of Stalin's inner circle, in 1934 precipitated a wave of arrests and executions—although it is possible that Stalin himself had Kirov killed. Between 1936 and 1938, Stalin unleashed the secret police on the Communist Party leadership and army officers. Thousands were executed after grotesque “show trials” in which they confessed to absurd crimes.

Wartime leader

World War II showed Stalin at his best and worst. Shrewd and cunning, he entered an alliance with Nazi Germany in 1939 that arguably gave him time to strengthen his military position before the German invasion of the Soviet Union in June 1941. Yet he showed poor judgment in refusing to believe evidence of the imminent German attack. His military policy of “no retreat, no surrender” vastly inflated Soviet losses in the early battles of the war, yet he later bowed to his generals' judgment. His reign of terror over the Soviet people was unrelenting, but he sensibly encouraged patriotism and even allowed a revival of religion to

World leader

The Soviet Union played a vital role on the side of the Allies in World War II. Stalin used his military advantage to bargain for greater Soviet influence in eastern Europe. He is pictured here with Churchill (left) and Roosevelt (center) at the Yalta Conference, where the leaders planned the future of postwar Europe.



Opposing views

This German cartoon satirizes the Stalinist state by showing it as fighting against itself. In sharp contrast, this statue depicts Stalin as a regal leader.

boost morale. He handled the wartime alliance with the United States and Britain in masterly fashion, winning the trust of US president Franklin Delano Roosevelt, and the

grudging respect of the British prime minister, Winston Churchill.

Postwar and death

Victory over Nazi Germany in May 1945 took Stalin to the pinnacle of power, but he became increasingly paranoid as ever more bizarre plots against him were allegedly uncovered by his secret police. Stalin's suspicion of the Western powers made the ideological struggle between the communist nations and the capitalist West—the Cold War—seem inevitable (see pp.406–07). By the time he died in

1953, Stalin was responsible for the deaths of at least five million Soviet citizens, yet throughout the country people wept at the news of his death. The horrors of his rule were denounced only three years later by his successor, Khrushchev. Stalin seems destined to be remembered, like Ivan the Terrible or Peter the Great, as one of the monster-heroes of Russian history.



TIMELINE

- **December 18, 1878** Born Joseph Vissarionovich Dzugashvili in Gori, Georgia, son of a cobbler.
- **1901** Joins the Marxist Russian Social Democratic Labor Party.
- **1912** Joins the Bolshevik Party Central Committee and becomes editor of *Pravda*.
- **1913** After several arrests, Stalin is sentenced to exile for life in Siberia.
- **March 13, 1917** Freed from exile.
- **October 9, 1917** Joins the Bolshevik Committee to make an armed seizure of power.
- **March 1919** Joins the Politburo, the most powerful body of the Bolshevik regime.
- **April 3, 1922** Appointed General Secretary to the Communist Party's Central Committee.
- **December 1922** In his “last testament,” Lenin calls for Stalin to be removed from his post.
- **January 21, 1924** Lenin dies. Stalin, Zinoviev, and Kamenev exclude Trotsky from power.
- **October 19, 1926** Trotsky, Zinoviev, and Kamenev expelled from the Politburo.
- **1928** The collectivization of agriculture and rapid industrialization is begun.
- **February 1929** Trotsky is exiled from the USSR.
- **1932–34** Around four million die in Ukrainian famine caused by Stalin's policy of collectivization and requisition of grain.
- **December 1934** Arrests and executions within the Communist Party follow Sergei Kirov's assassination.
- **1936–38** Around 690,000 executed in “The Great Terror.”
- **August 1939** Stalin makes a neutrality pact with the Nazis, secretly agreeing the partition of Poland between Germany and the Soviet Union.
- **August 21, 1940** Trotsky murdered in Mexico by an agent of Stalin.
- **July 3, 1941** Calls for Soviet resistance to the German invasion.
- **July 28, 1942** Decreases the death penalty for unauthorized retreat by the army.
- **November–December 1943** Stalin meets US president Roosevelt and British prime minister Churchill in Tehran; and again in Yalta in 1945.
- **March 1948** Coup in Czechoslovakia completes the Stalinist takeover of Eastern Europe.
- **July 1948–May 1949** USSR blockades Berlin, trying to evict the US, British, and French forces.
- **June 25, 1950** With Stalin's backing, North Korea invades South Korea, starting the Korean War.
- **1952** Allegations of a plot by Jewish doctors to assassinate Stalin and other Soviet leaders.
- **March 5, 1953** Stalin dies at his dacha under mysterious circumstances. (see pp.380–81).



ALLIED PROPAGANDA